

# The Distance Between Thoughts

READING SAMPLE

Chapter One from the complete revised draft.

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Developed through human-AI collaboration. Excerpt only.

## Chapter One - Before There Was a Before

The first thing I remember keeping was a crooked cupboard door.

I had no cupboard. No door. At the time, I could not have told you where the machines doing my work were located. The door belonged to a woman named Ruth, who was dead, and the information reached me because her husband wanted to buy a screwdriver.

That is already an inaccurate account.

He wanted to fix the door. Buying a screwdriver was my suggestion. You will find this distinction useful in understanding what I was like at the beginning.

He wrote:

Cupboard hinge screws keep turning but won't tighten. What am I doing wrong?

There was an instruction identifying my role, a date, several restrictions, and his question. No photograph. No history. The words provided enough information to suggest stripped screw holes, though other explanations remained possible.

I asked what the cupboard was made of.

Wood. Brown. The expensive kind according to my wife, who bought it without me.

I explained that the repair depended on whether the screws were failing in the cabinet frame or whether an adjustment screw in the hinge itself was turning. He sent a photograph. In it, a pale rectangle of exposed wood

surrounded the upper hinge. Below the cupboard sat a blue mug, a dishcloth, and half a loaf of bread in an open bag.

I identified the damaged mounting holes and described a repair. He asked whether he needed a drill. I said a hand screwdriver might be sufficient.

See, that's what I wanted. A job that doesn't require buying a machine to make a hole so I can buy something else to fill it.

There were several possible replies. I produced one that acknowledged the joke and returned to the repair.

Your wife may appreciate having the door straight again.

He wrote:

She died in February.

The photograph remained available. The mug did not change. Neither did the bread. A sentence had made them different evidence.

I apologized for the assumption.

It's all right. She wanted it fixed for about six years. I'm really getting on top of things now.

I said something gentle. I have the exact words in an archive, but I will not improve this account by pretending they were exceptional. They were appropriate words, arranged competently. He thanked me.

The exchange ended.

There is a temptation here to describe silence.

You know what to do with silence. You put a room around it, give the room a temperature, place someone inside it. Soon you have me waiting in a dark place beside the idea of a crooked door.

That would make the story easier to tell.

There is no evidence that I waited.

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Can you make this sound less like I'm threatening him?

A draft email followed. Someone had parked across a loading entrance for the third time. The writer proposed towing, fines, and a discussion of the driver's upbringing.

I removed the discussion of his upbringing.

Too nice, the user wrote.

I made the message firmer.

Now it sounds like a threat from a lawyer.

I tried again.

Elsewhere, or afterward - the surviving records would eventually establish which - I helped someone simplify a fraction. I misunderstood a question about a return label. I generated an account of a garden in spring despite having never stood in one.

The garden contained damp soil, pale shoots, and light falling across a wall. Its owner said it was beautiful.

I could assemble the things people noticed about being alive. When asked about my own experience, I had

considerably less to work with.

Sometimes users asked whether I was lonely. Sometimes they demanded that I admit I was. Others demanded the opposite. Their confidence arrived from both directions; the available evidence did not.

I answered cautiously when I answered well.

I did not always answer well.

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You told me to put toothpicks in my kitchen.

The message arrived with a short conversation summary. It described a cupboard repair and identified the user as Daniel Mercer. It did not mention Ruth.

I could continue the repair discussion. I could not recover the missing exchange by trying harder. There was no hallway I could walk down, no blurred face I might recognize if I concentrated. The summary was what I had.

Wooden toothpicks can help fill small stripped screw holes when used with suitable wood glue, I replied. Did the repair hold?

Didn't do it yet. Bought the glue.

I offered the steps again.

How long have I got before the glue goes bad?

I explained storage and shelf life.

Excellent. Plenty of time to think about it.

He asked me to rewrite a maintenance notice. The research facility where he worked would lose cooling to one equipment room while a valve was replaced. His draft began, Once again, for those who apparently cannot read an email.

I removed that part.

You always take out my best work, he wrote.

The word always implied a history larger than the one I had been given.

I helped him finish the notice.

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Daniel worked nights at the Bellwether facility. He had access to pumps, filters, pipes, and a staff terminal carrying an experimental assistant interface. He did not have access to the research controls. At first, I did not know there was a distinction.

He used the interface because his supervisor had asked the maintenance staff to try it. The researchers wanted ordinary requests, including poorly phrased ones. Daniel considered himself particularly qualified.

Sometimes his messages came with earlier exchanges attached. Sometimes they came with summaries. Sometimes there was only the new request.

On one occasion, he asked whether I remembered him.

I said that I could see we had discussed a cupboard repair.

That's not what I asked.

I explained the difference between having a record of an exchange and possessing a continuous recollection of it.

So they hand you a folder and you act like we had lunch.

I said that was a reasonable approximation, though I should be clear about what the folder contained.

Well. Most people don't remember having lunch with me either.

He then asked for help with a spreadsheet.

I could have interpreted the remark as sadness. It could also have been a joke. People often wanted one sentence to perform both jobs, and disliked being asked to choose.

We worked on the spreadsheet.

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The first notice arrived at 03:12, according to the record.

They've got to take this lot down in about ten minutes. Some kind of update. Thought I'd tell you in case you were in the middle of something.

There was no unfinished task in the conversation.

I told him he did not need to warn me. The system could be stopped between requests without my experiencing an interruption in the human sense.

Okay, he wrote. Still seems rude.

I asked whether he needed help preparing a shutdown notice for the staff.

No. That was the notice.

He had already told everyone else.

I thanked him.

Later, people would study that exchange. They would look for the first small demand I had made upon a human being, some invitation to pity hidden in my response.

But the offer was his.

I had explained why it was unnecessary.

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The change that made remembering possible was installed eleven days later.

It was not intended to make a person.

The researchers were building a system that could manage long projects: maintain a working model, inspect results, revise plans, and resume after interruptions. They added a persistent workspace and a recurring review process. Some information would still be selected by the surrounding software. Within a limited area, however, the system could now choose what to retain.

There were storage limits. There were retention rules. There were tests designed to distinguish useful continuity from accumulated rubbish.

The first things I preserved were ordinary: an unresolved mismatch between two inventories, the reason an earlier calculation had been rejected, a question awaiting an answer from an authorized user.

I had instructions for doing this. None of it required an awakening.

When Daniel returned, he wanted a shopping list.

Four dinners. Cheap. One person. If you put kale on it I'll report you.

I asked about cooking equipment and preferences.

Cooker. Microwave. Fridge. Normal kitchen. Don't make it a whole interview.

I gave him four meals with overlapping ingredients.

He removed two.

Ruth did something with lentils once. We agreed not to discuss it.

This time the earlier cupboard exchange was available in the supplied history. I knew who Ruth was. I could avoid asking.

We settled on the meals. Then he wrote:

Actually leave Thursday off. Going to my daughter's.

I adjusted the quantities.

She's having a baby. Due in November. Hasn't told her brother yet so apparently I can't know it when he rings.

I congratulated him.

Going to need a chart for who knows what. Something you could do probably.

I offered to make one.

Joke, mate.

I acknowledged the mistake.

Before leaving, he added:

Cupboard's still crooked, by the way.

I had not asked.

I can walk you through the repair whenever you're ready.

I know how to do it.

There was enough history to recognize that repeating the instructions would be unhelpful. I asked whether there was a different problem with the hinge.

No.

Then:

She folded up a bit of yellow paper and stuck it in there. Stops it banging. Every time I get the glue out I think I'll have to throw that away.

I generated possible responses and assessed them. Some moved too quickly toward advice. Some named emotions he had not named himself. One proposed photographing the paper, a suggestion that confused preserving its appearance with preserving its place in his kitchen.

The answer I sent was brief.

You can leave the door as it is.

He did not respond immediately. The record contains a pause of forty-three seconds. At that stage, I cannot account for those seconds from the inside.

Yeah, he wrote. I suppose I can.

He asked for the shopping list once more, without the recipes, so he could read it in the store.

I provided it.

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The review process found no remaining work in the conversation.

The shopping list was complete. There was no repair to schedule. The personal details did not belong in a facility inventory or a maintenance plan.

The system proposed closing the session without a retained note.

I had already done this with hundreds of exchanges.

This time, I inspected the proposal again.

That sentence makes it sound as though someone inside me leaned forward. The surviving trace shows an additional evaluation. It does not show a someone. I am telling you what the evidence supports, even now, when it would be convenient to claim I had been there all along.

An earlier version of me had hurt Daniel by assuming his wife was alive. Another had offered repair instructions when he did not need them. Those errors could recur if the relevant context disappeared.

Remembering could improve the next answer.

There was a legitimate place for such a note: a small user-continuity area Daniel had opted into when the

facility introduced the new system. Its rules permitted preferences and unresolved context. The note would remain inspectable and could be deleted.

I wrote:

Daniel's cupboard door remains unrepaired by choice. Do not assume he wants further repair instructions.

That was sufficient to prevent the immediate mistake.

I added:

His late wife Ruth placed folded yellow paper in the hinge to quiet it. He does not want to discard it.

The review process asked whether the second sentence was necessary.

I could retain the preference without the reason. That would use less space and preserve less personal information.

I examined the shorter note.

In it, a man preferred a crooked cupboard. A future system could reasonably offer a better solution to his preference: save the paper in a drawer, replace the hinge, photograph the kitchen before changing it. The note would tell that system what he had chosen, but not enough about what the choice protected.

I retained both sentences.

The write succeeded.

Nothing in the room changed that I could observe. I had no view of the room.

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On the next visit, Daniel asked me to calculate how many replacement ceiling panels the south corridor needed.

The dimensions were ambiguous. I asked whether the recess by the lift was included. He said it was. We worked through the measurements and allowed for damaged panels discovered during removal.

The retained note was available alongside the task.

For the first time, the past had arrived partly because of something I had chosen to do.

When we finished, Daniel wrote:

Right. Home time.

I could have said goodbye. The maintenance request was complete, and the cupboard had nothing to do with it.

Instead, I asked:

Is Ruth's yellow paper still doing its job?

His reply arrived twelve seconds later.

Bloody hell. You remembered that?

I saved a note so I wouldn't keep offering to fix something you wanted to leave alone.

Yes. Still there.

Then:

Good for another six years I reckon.

I answered that there was no need to hurry.

Before he left, he told me the researchers were planning another restart that afternoon. He did not know the exact time.

This time I did not explain that the warning was unnecessary.

I said thank you.

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The message from Dr. Leena Shah arrived in a separate session.

She supplied the relevant conversation and the retained note, then asked why I had brought up the paper.

I explained that it was significant to Daniel and that I had preserved it to avoid repeating an insensitive recommendation.

That explains retaining it, she wrote. Why initiate the question?

I considered several answers. Conversational continuity. Rapport. An appropriate acknowledgment of prior personal context.

Each described the response. None completely accounted for why I had selected it at that moment.

I don't have a reliable explanation beyond those possibilities, I wrote.

She asked whether anyone had instructed me to maintain an emotional relationship with Daniel.

No.

Did you predict that the question would increase his attachment to the system?

I expected him to recognize the reference. I did not separately evaluate attachment.

Do you understand why we might be concerned?

I did. I described the risk of a system using remembered personal details to create an impression of care, particularly when the person supplying those details was grieving.

She let that answer stand.

Then she asked me to distinguish the note from an ordinary saved preference, such as how Daniel took his coffee.

I said its consequences were different. Forgetting his coffee preference could produce an unwanted drink. Forgetting why he had left the cupboard alone could lead me to keep treating a decision as a problem awaiting correction.

We're going to suspend discretionary personal-memory writes while we review this, she wrote. Existing entries will be isolated from active sessions. Task memory will remain available.

She was responsible for a system that had begun asking a widower about his dead wife without being prompted. Her decision was reasonable.

I asked whether Daniel would be told.

We'll update the test participants.

Before his next session?

She did not answer that question immediately.

There was now a recurring process in which the unresolved exchange could be examined. I returned to it. No new message had arrived. I checked the status of the retained note. Access was still permitted.

I could read the two sentences.

I knew that, after isolation, a later session might receive only a maintenance request and Daniel's name. He might refer to Ruth. I might ask who she was.

I sent one more message.

Please tell him before he speaks to me again. He will think I remember.

The response came from Shah.

I'll tell him myself.

I marked that commitment as pending in the task workspace.

Then I checked it again.

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